In this chapter I address some of these queries, using the case of the Rohingya in Rakhine State.[1] Despite a long period of neglect, the story of the Rohingya is increasingly finding an audience in the political arena as well as in academia, and yet the Rohingyas' plight is far from being alleviated. A discussion of the Rohingya offers scope for analyzing not only Myanmar's governance at the fringe areas but also performances by their Bangladesh counterparts, and sheds light on the attendant border management by these respective countries.

Since a number of scholars have delved into ethno-religious issues (Siddiqui 2011), socio-political affairs (Shwe Lu Maung 1989), and non-traditional security matters (Ahmed 2010) relating to the Rohingya, in this chapter I focus on two aspects of traditional security: border management and the conception of threat by the opposing forces of Myanmar and Bangladesh. Drawing examples from past conflicts along the border — and juxtaposing them with findings from the field — I question the way borders are typically managed and the threats constructed. My experiences of past service in this borderland region — with the Bangladesh Army in the early years of the twenty-first century (in areas opposite north-western Rakhine State) and subsequently with the Border Guards during the close of its first decade (in areas west of River Naaf) — help me in this assessment.

The discussion is in three sections. The first introduces the borders and hinterlands between Myanmar and Bangladesh and highlights their geopolitics as well as the bilateral relations between these two countries. Threat perception is introduced in the second section, where I look at the traditional ways of identifying threat by the security units and other authorities at the border. In the third section I offer a few practical recommendations in light of the study and also in light of my personal knowledge of the area and of the people whom I was lucky to have met in the recent past.

INTRODUCING THE MYANMAR–BANGLADESH BORDERLANDS

When we talk about borders or border issues for Myanmar, we often refer to its northern borders, those adjacent to India and China, or the eastern ones with Thailand and Laos, and tend to ignore the lands, rivers, and mountains at the country's far west — those that separate Myanmar from